New Minor Forcing

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New Minor Forcing is a convention used after responder bids 1♥/♠ and hears a 1NT rebid by opener. A 2♣ or 2♦ bid is artificial, showing at least game-invitational values and usually a 5-card major. It says nothing about clubs or diamonds, respectively. New Minor Forcing is used in these sequences:

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥/♠
1NT	2♦!

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥/♠
1NT	2♣!

Opener	Responder
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♣/♦!

In each auction, 2♣/♦ is New Minor Forcing. These bids do not promise a real suit; they are simply forcing bids that ask partner to describe his hand further.

The last auction above is the only one where responder can choose a minor. In their book "Modern Bridge Conventions", Bill Root and Richard Pavlicek recommend bidding the stronger minor to imply a stopper.

New Minor Forcing fulfills the need to identify a 5-3 major-suit fit, since opener's 1NT rebid may include 3 cards in responder's suit. Playing standard methods, responder may be forced to rebid 2NT or 3NT with a 5-card major. Opener is then forced to guess whether responder has a 4- or 5-card suit. By playing New Minor Forcing and giving up the natural minor-suit rebid, players can more easily probe for a major-suit game.

Opener's Rebids

Opener's priorities are:

1. Bidding a 4-card major
2. Showing 3-card support for partner's major
3. Bidding no-trumps with a stopper in the unbid suit
4. Raising the "new minor" with 4 cards in that suit
5. Rebidding his suit if none of the above conditions are met

Note that the examples below illustrate a 12-14 HCP 1NT rebid by opener. If playing a weak 1NT opening bid, then opener's 1NT rebid would show 15-17 HCP, and responder's minimum strength would be revised downward accordingly.

1. Bidding a 4-card major

This is opener's top priority in case a 4-4 fit is available. When both a 4-4 fit and 5-3 fit are available, the 4-4 fit is generally preferred because the 5-card suit can theoretically be cashed to provide discards.

Opener	Responder
♠KJ7	♠AT932
♥AQT7	♥K932
♦A563	♦J2
♣65	♣KT

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♠
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♥ (2)	3♥ (3)
4♥ (4)	Pass

1. New Minor Forcing.
2. Opener's top priority is to bid his 4-card heart suit.
3. Responder raises with 4-card support and game-invitational values.
4. Opener bids game with a maximum.

2. Showing 3-card support for partner's major

With 12-13 points and 3-card support, opener should bid partner's suit at the 2-level. With a good 13-14 points, opener should jump raise.

Opener	Responder
♠JT3	♠KQ2
♥KJT	♥A7532
♦A4	♦Q32
♣K9632	♣87

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥
1NT	2♦ (1)
2♥ (2)	Pass (3)

1. New Minor Forcing.
2. Opener shows 3-card support and minimum strength. (He also denies as many as four spades.)
3. Responder passes with a minimum opposite a minimum. New Minor Forcing does NOT promise a rebid.

Opener	Responder
♠J73	♠KQ2
♥KQT	♥A7532
♦A4	♦Q32
♣A9632	♣87

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥
1NT	2♦ (1)
3♥ (2)	4♥ (3)

1. New Minor Forcing.

2. Opener shows 3-card support and maximum strength. (He also denies as many as four spades.)
3. Responder continues on to game knowing partner has a maximum.

3. Bidding no-trumps with a stopper in the unbid suit

Opener can rebid 2NT (with 12-13 points) or 3NT (with 13-14 points) if he lacks a 4-card major or support for partner's major. A rebid in no-trumps promises a stopper in the unbid suit.

Opener	Responder
♠KT3	♠94
♥84	♥AJ975
♦A97	♦KQT62
♣KQ632	♣8

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥
1NT	2♦ (1)
2NT (2)	3♦ (3)
Pass (4)	

1. New Minor Forcing.
2. Opener promises a spade stopper with 12-13 points.
3. Rebidding the "new minor" shows at least a 4-card suit. With game-forcing values, responder could jump-rebid either of his suits instead.
4. Opener passes with a minimum.

Opener	Responder
♠AKT	♠62
♥84	♥AJ975
♦A97	♦KQ2
♣KT832	♣A74

Opener	Responder
1♣	1♥
1NT	2♦ (1)
3NT (2)	Pass

1. New Minor Forcing.
2. Opener promises a spade stopper with 13-14 points.

4. Raising the "new minor" with 4 cards in that suit

This bid occurs when opener cannot bid the other major, raise partner's suit or bid no-trumps.

Opener	Responder
♠Q9	♠AT42
♥84	♥AJ975
♦A9752	♦KQ4
♣KQ63	♣8

Opener	Responder
1♦	1♥
1NT	2♣ (1)

3♣ (2)	3NT (3)
Pass	

1. New Minor Forcing.
2. Natural, denying a lot of things: four spades, a spade stopper, or heart support.
3. Responder is able to bid 3NT with game-going strength and a spade stopper.

5. Rebidding his suit if none of the above conditions are met

This is opener's last resort. He lacks a 4-card major, a stopper in the unbid suit, 3-card support for partner, and he cannot raise the "new minor."

Opener	Responder
♠K7	♠AT932
♥AJT75	♥K6
♦963	♦JT8
♣A52	♣KT3

Opener	Responder
1♥	1♠
1NT	2♣ (1)
2♥ (2)	2NT (3)
Pass (4)	

1. New Minor Forcing.
2. Opener has neither 3-card spade support nor a diamond stopper. He also cannot raise clubs.
3. Responder bids no-trumps with a club control. Note that he could bid 3NT with a maximum instead.
4. Opener passes with a minimum.

See also

- Checkback Stayman
  A variation of the Stayman convention after opener rebids 1NT.
- Crowhurst
  A 2♣ checkback bid by responder, when playing a weak 1NT.
- Fourth-Suit Forcing
  An artificial, forcing bid after the partnership has already bid the other three suits naturally.
- Roudi
  A conventional 2♣ rebid by responder to check back for major suit support.
- Two-Way Checkback
  An extension of Checkback Stayman. After opener rebids 1NT, the 2♣ and 2♦ responses are game-invitational and game-forcing, respectively.